

ENGLISH FOR WORK / SEPTEMBER 2026

# Data Analytics and Business Intelligence English

## Vocabulary & phrasebook

Keep precise meanings and useful expressions close. Retrieve the words, then use them in a complete message.

### PRACTICE THAT TRANSFERS TO WORK

Read a realistic case. Find the right language. Speak, write, get feedback, and try again.

Eight lessons | Intermediate to advanced | Independent or classroom study

For data analysts, BI developers, analytics engineers, data scientists, reporting teams, business analysts, and data-driven managers.

All cases and figures are fictional. Adapt the language to your role and organization's current procedures, using invented details for practice.

All scenarios, figures, and model responses are fictional teaching material. Use invented details in practice.

[Open this course on English Ladder](#)

# Make vocabulary usable

Knowing a definition is a start. To use a term well, explain it in plain English, connect it to a case, and choose a natural sentence around it.

- Read five terms, cover their definitions, and recall the meanings.
- Sort a pair you might confuse and explain the difference.
- Use one term in a sentence about a fictional case.
- Ask a partner to explain the sentence without repeating the specialist word.
- Return to the same terms on another day and test recall again.

## Abbreviations need context

Expand an abbreviation on first use when the listener needs it. Some abbreviations have different meanings across professions: API can refer to an application programming interface or an active pharmaceutical ingredient. The course context determines the meaning.

## Definitions have limits

These are concise language-learning explanations, not complete legal, clinical, or technical specifications. Use the applicable authoritative definition for regulated or operational decisions.

# Field vocabulary A-Z

**access control**

Rules and mechanisms that determine who may use information or a system.

**assumption**

Something treated as true for planning or reasoning, though it may need verification.

**business definition**

An agreed explanation of what a measure or term means in an organization.

**causation**

A relationship in which a change in one factor produces a change in another.

**completeness**

The extent to which required information or records are present.

**confidence interval**

An interval produced by a method with a stated long-run coverage rate under its assumptions.

**confounder**

A factor related to both a proposed cause and outcome that can distort their apparent relationship.

**correlation**

A statistical association between variables; it does not by itself establish causation.

**dashboard**

Visual summary of selected measures used to monitor status, performance, or risk.

**data governance**

The responsibilities and rules for managing data quality, access, use, and protection.

**data model**

A representation of how data is structured and how its elements relate.

**data quality**

How well data meets requirements for its intended use, such as accuracy and completeness.

**drill-down**

Moving from a summary measure to more detailed information behind it.

**effect size**

A measure of the magnitude of a difference or relationship.

**freshness**

How recently data reflects events in the source system.

**grain**

What one row or record represents in a dataset.

**guardrail**

A boundary or protective check used to prevent an unacceptable outcome.

**insight**

An interpretation of evidence that improves understanding of a question or decision.

**join logic**

The rules used to connect records from different data tables.

**KPI**

Key performance indicator used to monitor progress against an important objective.

**metric**

A defined quantitative measure used to track or assess something.

**next best action**

The action judged most useful for a stated objective given current information.

**owner**

Named person or role accountable for a decision, action, deliverable, or risk.

**pipeline**

A sequence of stages through which data, work, or sales opportunities move.

**privacy**

The appropriate handling of personal information and individuals' related interests and rights.

**recommendation**

A proposed action supported by reasons and relevant evidence.

**retention**

Keeping customers, users, staff, or records over a stated period; specify which meaning applies.

**sample size**

The number of independent units or observations included in a defined analysis.

**selection bias**

Distortion caused by how people or observations are selected into a study or dataset.

**source of truth**

The agreed authoritative reference for a particular item of organizational information.

**SQL**

Structured Query Language: a language for querying and working with relational data.

**threshold**

A defined value or condition that triggers a decision or changes a classification.

# Expressions for this course

Complete the frames with the facts of your case. A frame helps organize meaning; it should not replace an actual explanation.

## Ask a precise question

When you say ..., do you mean ...?

Could you clarify which ...?

So, my understanding is ... . Is that right?

Name the exact word, fact, or requirement you need clarified. Ask one focused question at a time. Repeat your understanding and give the other person a chance to correct it.

## Give a useful status update

We have completed ...; ... remains open.

As of ..., the status is ... .

The next update will cover ... .

Lead with the current state, then the important change or open item. Use completed-action language only for completed work. Add a next update point when it is known; do not invent a date to make the message sound complete.

## Make a complex point clear

In this context, ... means ... .

The difference is that ... .

How would you explain that distinction to a colleague?

Start with the reader's question. Explain one unfamiliar term with familiar words, then give a relevant example or contrast. Check understanding without asking only 'Do you understand?'.

## Match certainty to evidence

The available evidence shows ... .

This may indicate ..., but ... .

We have not yet established whether ... .

Say what the evidence shows, identify what is still unknown, and limit the conclusion to that evidence. Words such as 'may', 'suggests', and 'in this sample' are useful when the uncertainty is real. Do not soften an urgent, verified safety concern.

## Ask for an actionable next step

Could you provide ... so that ...?

Please confirm ... by [agreed time].

If that timing is not possible, please let me know ... .

State the action and the information needed. Explain why it matters and specify a deadline only when one is given or agreed. 'Could you' is polite; repeated apologies can obscure a legitimate request. Urgent situations may require a direct request.

# Model responses in context

Read the situation first. Cover the model, say your own response, and compare the two for meaning and tone.

## 01 | Metric Definitions and Business Questions

Two teams report different active-user totals. One counts logins; the other counts completed transactions.

What action qualifies a user as active, and over what period? The two totals use different definitions. Let's agree on the business question and label each measure clearly.

Try it again: The other person uses an ambiguous word such as 'ready', 'approved', or 'urgent'. Clarify it before continuing.

## 02 | Data Quality and Trust

A dashboard refreshed today, but one source table contains data only through Monday. A manager assumes all figures are current.

The dashboard refreshed today, but that table is current only through Monday. I'll show the source's data cutoff separately from the dashboard refresh time.

Try it again: The listener asks you to reduce the update to two sentences. Preserve the most important completed and pending items.

## 03 | Dashboards and Executive Reporting

A KPI card shows a monthly total without its target, comparison period, or definition. The reader cannot interpret whether the result is favorable.

The total needs context. I'll add the definition, reporting period, and relevant comparison so the reader can understand what changed and whether action is needed.

Try it again: Your listener is new to this field. Replace two specialist expressions with clear explanations without changing the meaning.

## 04 | Causation, Correlation, and Caveats

Customers who attend training renew more often. Attendance was voluntary, and the groups may differ in motivation.

Training attendance is associated with renewal in this dataset. That does not establish causation; the groups may differ in other ways. I'll state the finding with that limitation.

Try it again: Someone asks for a yes-or-no answer when the evidence supports only a qualified answer. Be concise while preserving the uncertainty.



## 05 | SQL, Models, and Transformation Logic

A report joins order rows to several payment rows per order. Revenue appears larger after the join.

What does one row represent in each table? The join may repeat order values when there are multiple payments. Let's check the grain and aggregation before interpreting the total.

Try it again: The other person uses an ambiguous word such as 'ready', 'approved', or 'urgent'. Clarify it before continuing.

## 06 | Experiment Readouts and Statistical Thinking

An experiment estimates a positive effect, but the interval includes values close to no change. The slide presents only the point estimate.

I'll show the estimated effect and its uncertainty together. The point estimate alone hides the range of values compatible with the analysis and can make the result sound more certain than it is.

Try it again: Someone asks for a yes-or-no answer when the evidence supports only a qualified answer. Be concise while preserving the uncertainty.

## 07 | Data Governance and Privacy

An analyst wants customer-level data but has not specified which fields are needed or how long they will be retained.

Could you define the analysis purpose, necessary fields, and retention period? That will let the appropriate team review access and privacy requirements before the data is shared.

Try it again: The other person cannot meet the requested timing. Clarify an alternative without inventing authority to change a formal deadline.

## 08 | Insight Storytelling and Recommendations

A report lists ten findings but no recommended action. The audience has five minutes to decide whether to investigate a service issue.

I'll lead with the finding relevant to that decision, explain its limitation, and recommend a specific investigation. The other findings can support the discussion without obscuring the request.

Try it again: Your listener is new to this field. Replace two specialist expressions with clear explanations without changing the meaning.

# Use the language responsibly

All cases and figures are fictional. Adapt the language to your role and organization's current procedures, using invented details for practice.

## Meaning before performance

Use specialist terms only when they help the listener. Explain unfamiliar words, preserve uncertainty, and ask when an instruction or responsibility is unclear. The model responses illustrate language; they do not authorize professional actions.

## Sources and further reading

The cases, workshops, and explanations are original teaching material. These references provide language frameworks and selected professional context. References were checked in September 2026; consult current local guidance for actual work.

### Digital.gov: plain-language guidance

<https://digital.gov/guides/plain-language>

### Council of Europe: CEFR descriptors

<https://www.coe.int/en/web/common-european-framework-reference-languages/cefr-descriptors>

## Your next step

Choose one expression you can use in a genuine work situation. Rehearse it with fictional details, then adapt the wording to your role and audience.